The Social Radars
Justin Kan, CoFounder, Twitch

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Jessica (00:00:00):

Carolyn, I'm so excited. Today we have Justin Kahn on the show. Hi, Justin.

Carolynn (00:00:09):

Welcome, Justin.

Justin (00:00:10):

Hey, what's up guys? So happy to be here. Nice to see you.

Jessica (00:00:13):

We're so excited. So for any listener who doesn't happen to know who Justin is, he's the founder of ... Well, originally it was Justin TV, but that turned into Twitch. So he's the founder of Twitch. And we're going to talk a lot about Twitch, but even more than that because we have known Justin for ... I've known him for 20 years now because he and Emmett Shear were in the very first Y Combinator batch in 2005. Can you believe it?

Carolynn (00:00:42):

That's amazing.

Justin (00:00:42):

That is crazy. It's crazy that we've known each other for 20 years because I remember coming into this industry and hearing people be like, "Oh yeah, I've known that guy for 15, 20 years." And I was like, "Wow, that's a long time." It's a long

Jessica (00:00:57):

Time. I've had kids in that time, you've had kids in that time. It's just been just a lot of changes.

Carolynn (00:01:06):

How old were you when you did YC?

Justin (00:01:08):

I was 22. Yeah, 22. I think I went through my 22nd birthday actually during YC in 2005. Yeah, that was crazy. I knew nothing about anything at the time.

Jessica (00:01:21):

So you applied to YC during your senior year at Yale, is that right?

Justin (00:01:27):

Yeah, that's right. So Emmett and I had a company with our other friend, Matt. We had this calendar company, maybe you remember. It was called Kiko.

Jessica (00:01:36):

Maybe I remember. Give me irate. Kiko, come on.

Justin (00:01:42):

One of the classics when we had this idea, we saw Gmail come out and we had this idea for making a calendar version of Gmail, and we didn't know anything about internet startups or how you would make money from it or anything. We just thought, "Hey, that'd be a cool product." And so we started learning to build a web app at the time. And then senior year, we were kind of working on this while we were going to classes. And our friend, the stroke of luck or fate or whatever that changed our lives forever sent us, he got an email from Paul advertising Y Combinator Summer Founders program and he was like, "Hey, you guys have a company. Maybe you should check this out. " Who was the

Jessica (00:02:25):

Friend? Was it a guy at Yale?

Justin (00:02:28):

Yeah, and he was a friend of Emet's. He was in the computer science department at Yale. And we got the email the day before the application process was due. That was maybe March or April of 2005 or something like that. And then I was like, "We should do it. Let's apply right now." And so Emmet and I spent all night writing the application, deciding what kind of animal we were or whatever, and then submitted it the next day. That changed it forever for us.

Jessica (00:02:55):

Had you ever heard of Paul? Had you ever read an essay?

Justin (00:02:58):

Yeah, Emmett had been a fan of Paul. That's why he was excited to apply, because you'd heard of Paul and I hadn't really been into CS before. So I hadn't heard of Paul before, but Emmett was super excited. So we were like, "Hey, someone might give us money for the company. That would be crazy. We should definitely try to do that.

Jessica (00:03:20):

" I definitely remember your interview, and it would've been in March 2005 for the summer. We were going to have the first dinner in June, and you guys were totally legit. You had started working on the product. And to be fair, the idea was amazing. I mean, too bad Google launched Google Calendar, but your idea was really solid. You could build it. You were from Yale. We were like, "Yes." Do you remember that interview?

Justin (00:03:52):

Yeah, I remember the interview. What happened was we came in, we took the train into Boston and stayed at the Somerville La Quinta Inn, which was really ... I mean, I think Somerville gentrified a lot at the time, but that was really sketch. And then we were trying to get a taxi in the morning because there's

no Uber or anything. And it was so hard to get a cab that we were a little late. I think we were five or 10 minutes late and I was dying inside. But we got there, you were super nice. You were like, "Oh, it's not a problem." So we go in and then we're opening. We had been up until 3:00 or 4:00 AM trying to make a demo. Our demo work really well. And so we get in, show the demo, it's a calendar app. It's basically like Google Calendar except shittier in every way, but the same idea of you're going to make appointments, drag and drop them around.

(00:04:42):

Stuff we take for granted now, but that didn't exist in 2005. And then Emmett basically spent the entire time arguing with mostly Trevor, but also RTM and Paul about whether fat client apps, like JavaScript heavy apps would be a thing or not. Because most of the apps at the time, 20 years ago were built where they were all done on the server and then the server would send you a small page to render. And our app was like Gmail, which was more like intense on the client side, on the end user computer. The interviews were 40, 40 minutes at the time. And it was like seven minutes of us demoing our thing and like 33 minutes about arguing about

Jessica (00:05:26):

CS. And I'll tell you, I'm sure the reason why was because we had already decided, yes, we're funding them, so let's just get into some cool conversation. Because arguing

Justin (00:05:36):

Means

Jessica (00:05:36):

You're doing well.

Justin (00:05:38):

Yes. For sure. It's like you're engaged, right? Yeah.

Jessica (00:05:40):

But when things are silent and like Trevor does all the talking, that was the bad sign. Trevor. But that was the deathnell when Trevor was spearheading the interview at that point because Paul had checked out I'm making

Justin (00:05:54):

Kimble and Giggle.

Jessica (00:05:55):

Paul had totally checked out. RTM never spoke anyway. So that just meant we liked you guys and knew we were going to fund you.

Justin (00:06:03):

Yeah. After that, we walked over to Harvard Square and we were walking around for the afternoon. And then at the end of the afternoon, you guys called us and we're like, "Hey, we want to fund your company." And we were jumping for joy in the street.

Jessica (00:06:17):

Now, I remember you both had offers that you'd accepted from, he was going to Microsoft and you were going to a consulting firm and you had gotten like a $10,000 signing bonus or something, right?

Justin (00:06:29):

Yeah. And so I sent the signing bonus back to this company, which was like, that's like the most money I'd ever seen in my life. So that was crazy. But you know me, I want to do my own thing and like Emmett too. So we just were like, "This is our shot to do something. Let's just see what happens."

Jessica (00:06:48):

So you moved to, God, where did you move to Boston?

Justin (00:06:52):

Oh, we moved to Roxbury, which was awful. But we moved to Roxbury into this-

Jessica (00:06:59):

Why

Justin (00:06:59):

Did you move there? Because it was cheapest. It was the cheapest place. Of course it was

Jessica (00:07:02):

Cheapest, dude.

Justin (00:07:04):

We used to

Jessica (00:07:05):

Get shot there.

Justin (00:07:06):

Yeah, we never saw it. A friend of mine who lived in Boston, like a family friend, we were like, "Hey, can you check out this place on Craigslist?" The guy looked and he was like, "This is totally fine." We got there and we were like, "Great." But we were just basically in this apartment all summer hacking on the ... There was no air conditioning. It was Boston summer. So the window shades were all drawn and it was like we tried to keep it as blacked out in there as possible. We were just sitting in the dark working on this application all summer. And afterwards, we moved to Summerville after that, which was also not that great, but it was better.

Jessica (00:07:43):

So tell me some of your best memories from that summer batch.

Justin (00:07:49):

Yeah, it was just startups. It's so funny because I feel like YC hit so many core things that make YCYC in the early days, either because you and Paul were so spot on of what was needed or by accident or some combination of the two. It's like the batch thing. So I remember going through with other companies and being like, oh, we got to crank some code out because these other people are legit and I don't want to look stupid in front of these like Steve, Steve Huffman and Aaron and all the other people were so smart. I felt like we're like remedial. We need to crank something out.

(00:08:32):

So that was really motivating. And then just the speakers, the speakers weren't that good back then, but there were some really great ones. Steven Wolfram was a speaker. And then Langley from TripAdvisor who had worked with Paul before, and he had sold TripAdvisor for like 300 mil or something. So it's still a lot, right? But back then, that was a lot, a lot. And we were like, whoa, you can do this. Someone could start a company, just set up a website and it could be worth $300 million in some number of years. That is crazy. And so it was very inspiring to like, "Hey, it's possible to do something." And now 20 years later, there's a lot more infrastructure and knowledge about startups and YouTube videos and everything. But at the time, it was very opaque that anyone could even start a company.

Jessica (00:09:23):

There was so little information out there. And actually, if I remember, we had limited access to speakers because we didn't have that many connections and also there weren't that many startup founders in Boston, but also we were trying to bring in sort of the business side of things. So we would bring in a patent attorney to talk to the startups. When the truth is, it took us a year or two to learn, they don't care about hearing from a patent attorney. They just want to hear from the founders. But I'm glad to hear that you enjoyed the speakers. I think Paul and I, this is before we were married and had kids, we used to take you guys to dinner every once in a while, right? Yeah.

Justin (00:10:03):

That was always fun. So Paul was cooking dinner for us every Tuesday, which was awesome. And it felt like a very family feel, which was really nice. Having dinner with people, trying to be like, "Hey, we need to present something or show other people. " Paul was like, "Hey, every week you should be demoing to your peers batch mates and showing some progress." And then we really were like, "Oh yeah, we need to do that. " And then his encouragement to just launch early and often or it took us, I think we launched at the end of summer or something, but that was really powerful advice. I mean, I think we made tons of mistakes ultimately at this company, but I think that original format, those things persist to today, which is- Yeah, it hasn't changed that

Jessica (00:10:52):

Much, really.

Justin (00:10:53):

Exactly. The whole flow of it, which is like come in, work on your idea, try to show progress every week, kind of reporting to your peers. And it's more of like a, feels like you have a peer set in something that would otherwise be lonely, and then working up towards a demo day, that all existed. It's just gotten bigger and better and more streamlined in every axis.

Jessica (00:11:18):

One of my favorite subjects is talking about the very first demo day, because it was so embarrassing. Do you remember there were like

Justin (00:11:28):

12

Jessica (00:11:28):

People in the audience?

Justin (00:11:30):

Yeah, there was like 12 people. They were all friends of Paul's who he'd made money for or worked with him at Via Web, but we did get an investor from it. Alex Lewin, who worked for Paul, his friend of Paul's who just clearly came by to check it out and he ended up investing $12,000 around. And then he introduced us to someone else who had worked with Paul at Yahoo. He was like Yahoo employed Linda. Yeah.

Jessica (00:11:56):

Very

Justin (00:11:57):

Early

Jessica (00:11:57):

Yahoo employee, Carolyn.

Justin (00:12:00):

Yeah. Oh,

Jessica (00:12:00):

Those were your two investors, right?

Justin (00:12:03):

Those were our two investors where he's like $62,000 and Paul put in some more money because he felt bad for us. And then we were on our way to starting this company and yeah, the demo day was like ... I don't know, it worked. We got our start. If we were smarter, we probably could have made that company work better, but you have to learn. And we got our learning from that year working on that company.

Jessica (00:12:31):

Well, here's what I want to know though.

Justin (00:12:33):

Yeah.

Jessica (00:12:33):

So that was the same time right after we finished that demo day, that's when Paul and I decided, "Gosh, we got to go to Silicon Valley because we don't want someone else to be the Y Combinator of Silicon Valley." So we said, "Hey guys, we're going to move to out and do our Y Combinator thing in the winter in Silicon Valley. You can stay working or we let you work out of the Garden Street office."

Justin (00:12:58):

I want to

Jessica (00:12:59):

Know what went on while I was away and no

Justin (00:13:03):

One was watching. So a bunch of us, you kind of like left us in Boston. And so a lot of people stayed there. I'm not sure everyone did, but a lot of people just stayed in Boston because that's where we all moved. Free

Carolynn (00:13:17):

Office space too.

Justin (00:13:18):

Yeah. So we're working at Garden Street. I was cooking dinner a lot of times for everybody and we'd just stay there working out of the office. I think Paul let me stay at his house for a week or two when I was like moving between apartments and- Well, this

Jessica (00:13:33):

Came up, Justin, because this is another famous story that you probably don't remember, but

Justin (00:13:39):

Paul- Did I leave this door open?

Jessica (00:13:41):

Yes, you

Justin (00:13:42):

Left. Yes, I do remember. I feel bad to this day. Yeah.

Jessica (00:13:45):

He literally, he was living in Paul's house, which was a nice house in Harvard Square. He left to leave to move out or whatever, wherever you were going and literally left the front door open.

Carolynn (00:14:00):

Just to be clear, unlocked open or hanging

Justin (00:14:04):

Open? I think a jar. I don't know what happened exactly. That's not like me. That's totally not like me, but yeah, I did-

Carolynn (00:14:11):

So what happened? I

Justin (00:14:13):

Think Paul's friend, Kate went by and was like, "Dude, the door's open. What is going on? " And then-Kate

Jessica (00:14:18):

Was irate. Because she was sort of in charge of looking after his house, just checking in on it. The front door was unlocked.

Justin (00:14:26):

Yeah. So Paul,

Jessica (00:14:28):

If you're listening, I'm sorry. That's okay. I just love giving you a hard time because it's so insane.

Justin (00:14:35):

Yeah, it's a super rude house guest move for sure.

Jessica (00:14:40):

But overall, was it a good year working out of Y Combinator's office?

Justin (00:14:45):

It was good. The positives were like, it was like school where we learned how to actually build production web apps and things. So before we had never had jobs, we never ... Honestly, we probably could have been better at starting a company if we had worked at a real company for two years, just to learn how to even do normal build scale web apps and write production code and work in an environment where you have managers and see people get managed. We were kind of reinventing all of that because we didn't know anything. So it was good. It was like we got kind of taken to school. And then socially, it was really amazing because we spent so much time with Steve Huffman, particularly who were ... He's one of our closest friends. We're all super close now, 20 years later. And we were spending time with Alexis and Aaron.

(00:15:33):

And that was fun. The hard part was we were not successful at executing our startup very well. And so eventually, Paul gave us every opportunity. We almost sold it to Yahoo and then that he made that connection. And then after they dipped and ghosted us, we ended up kind of sputtering out and yellow selling it on eBay. Well,

Jessica (00:15:58):

I want to

Justin (00:15:58):

Hear this story,

Jessica (00:16:00):

But I first want to ask you, do you remember when Google Calendar launched? Because it was like

Justin (00:16:05):

After demographic February 2006. Okay. So

Jessica (00:16:08):

What

Justin (00:16:08):

Happened that happened?

Jessica (00:16:10):

What happened?

Justin (00:16:11):

Well, basically Paul had kind of hooked up a tour of Silicon Valley. So he had used the Silicon Valley connections to set up meetings with Yahoo for all the companies. And then it wasn't so much that he had set up the meetings with Google, but he had brought in Chris Saka, I think, or someone else from Google, maybe a couple of people from Google, and then they had seen some of the startups. And so they set up some meetings with people, including ourselves. And so we had meetings with Yahoo and Google, and these were the two big Silicon Valley companies at the time, right? And the Yahoo flew us out, so they were basically both obviously working on improving their calendar stuff. Google didn't have a calendar, but they had Gmail. It's pretty obvious you want calendar with email. So Google was like, "We're not telling you whether we're working on this or not, but we'd love to learn about what you're doing." So we went out and told them all the stuff about what we're doing.

(00:17:05):

It's kind of like that scene from Silicon Valley where they brain rape the piper team. It's basically exactly like that. They won't tell us anything. They're not like, "Oh, we can't tell you if we're working on a calendar or whatever, but we want to know everything about exactly how you're designing and deciding everything." And we were pretty naive. We're 22, so we're like, "Here it is. " To be honest, I don't think any of our ideas were that novel or anything. So they were probably already working on everything and they were like, "These guys are mid." But then Yahoo we went into and they were so behind technically, they were like, "Oh, this is actually better than whatever we're doing." They were like, "Hey, we want to buy your company. We want you to come work here on the calendar product."

Carolynn (00:17:53):

Like

Justin (00:17:54):

An acquihire probably. Yeah, Aquire. And so we were like ... I remember the guy who was in charge of the acquisitions, the corp dev guy for the communications department, which was like Messenger, email and calendar at Yahoo. He called me and he said, "We're interested. Would you want to come work here?" And we were like, "Okay, maybe." And he said, "How much would you want? " And I remember I thought at the time I was like, "I want a million dollars for him and a million dollars for me, " which was insane. I remember I just turned down $12,000, which I thought was the biggest amount of money I'd ever seen. So that was an insane amount to me. So immediately, knowing nothing about negotiation, having no negotiation skills, I was like $2 million without a pause, no second pause. He was like $1 million.

(00:18:44):

And I was like, "Done, easy." And so he was like, "Yes. Okay, we'll give you one million." I mean, clearly he probably could have given us $2 million. I just was like, I crumpled like a tin foil.

Carolynn (00:18:58):

Did you remember though that you had to pay your investors back? So that wasn't all going to go to UNM.

Justin (00:19:02):

Yeah, yeah. I remember that. I remember the investors owned whatever percent of it. It was like 20%, 30% or something like that, whatever. But still, these amounts were like ... Anything was better than what I have my expectations. So he was like, "I'm going to get a contract or term sheet or whatever, and I'm going to email you in a couple days." So I was like, "Great." And then I never heard from him again.

Carolynn (00:19:31):

Even after he low balled you.

Justin (00:19:34):

Yeah, exactly. Did he want

Carolynn (00:19:34):

To buy you?

Justin (00:19:36):

Yeah. So what happened, I found out years later, his boss, the guy who ran communications had just hired someone to do a friend, like a person in Silicon Valley who had experience to rebuild a calendar and then they were like, "Oh, do we need these guys?" And so they were into it, but he thought, "Oh, I can actually save this. We should buy these guys." So he didn't come back until we know. He was just trying to work internally on it. And then eventually by the time he got clarity, that too much time had passed and he was just super embarrassed. So he just ghosted us. That's

Jessica (00:20:12):

Hysterical. Oh

Justin (00:20:14):

Gosh. They didn't improve. I don't even know if they've improved the calendar to date, but they didn't for like 10 years. It was the same. They basically did any progress for like a long time. But I know ill will. Afterwards, I was like, "Yo, thank you because if you didn't not buy us, then we would never have gone on to start our next company and Twitch."

Jessica (00:20:36):

So who

Justin (00:20:37):

Decided solid?

Jessica (00:20:38):

It was a bright idea to sell what you had, sell the assets on eBay.

Justin (00:20:43):

So we spent the rest of the year, Google Calendar came out. It was very crushing because their product was basically better than ours. Plus they had all the Gmail users. All our early adopter users started using their calendar. So we were like, okay, what are we now what? So we were thinking about pivoting. We built a bunch of different apps. We built a to- do list that's kind of like to doist. We built a family social network that was kind of like a genie or something like that. We built something that was kind of like an influencer scoring thing for MySpace actually. A lot of these ideas actually became businesses, but we were not good at marketing or launching them. So we kind of would do the technical side and then we didn't do any of the customer development. And so anyways, long story short, after about a year, we're like, "We don't know what we're doing.

(00:21:33):

We need to get out of this business and I feel guilty about raising this $80,000 or whatever we'd raise. So we need to pay back our investors." So we ended up ... I had seen a company sell itself on eBay. There's this company called Juxto, which was like this search engine. It was basically a webpage that in two iFrames searched Microsoft and Yahoo results, put them next to each other. But anyways, this guy sold this failing webpage on eBay for like $100,000. And I was like, "That's crazy. Maybe we can do the same thing." So decided to list our company on eBay, this was like fall of 2006. And yeah, we ended up fueling a bunch of offers for it. People were learning about, they were like, "Is this real?" Then they're calling us up and doing diligence. Then they kind of went viral on the internet because people were like, "Why are these guys still selling their startup on eBay?" And then the morning of, we got a bid back.

(00:22:29):

So it was like $80,000 was like the reserve. I think the reserve price was like 50,000 and it went to like 80,000. And the morning of, I was visiting friends of mine in New York and they're like 23 years old, so they lived in a really ratchet place in New York, no AC. So I'm like in my underwear at my friend's desktop computer refreshing our eBay page with like F5, like F5, F5, F5 at the morning of, it's like every minute pressing F, to see what the auction was at. And so it was at 80 and I was like, "Oh, that's crazy. We're going to actually pay back all of our investors." Then it went to like 100,000. And I was like, "Oh my God, I make a couple thousand dollars." And then it was like 113, 158, and it kept going up for the last 30 minutes until it reached like $258,100, which is a number that's permanently burned into my brain now.

(00:23:24):

The original

Carolynn (00:23:25):

Meme stock. Amazing. That is amazing.

Justin (00:23:29):

Yeah. So we went from failed founders to like, "Hey, we actually made money. That is insane." Not a lot, but it was more than zero. After we paid taxes and kind of distributed to the investors and stuff, we basically made what we would've made if we just got an entry level salary, but it was all in one lump sum at the end of the year.

Jessica (00:23:54):

Yeah. So it was enough to keep going. You could keep doing something new.

Justin (00:23:59):

Yeah. So the most important thing was before we were extremely discouraged about startups, we were like, "We suck." After that, we were like, "Hey, we're okay. We don't suck. We're not great, but we could keep doing this. " And so then we went to pitch Paul for another company because he was actually ... Paul was also super encouraging because he was like, "Hey, do you have any other ideas for another company to do next thing?" We were like, "You would fund another company of ours based on this experience That's amazing. Thank you for believing us." We were like, "That's crazy." So after we had sold the company, we went over to back to ... Where was it?

Jessica (00:24:43):

It was at Avon's house. Yeah, I was at

Justin (00:24:45):

Amanda.

Jessica (00:24:45):

I walked in during the meeting.

Justin (00:24:48):

And I'll never

Jessica (00:24:49):

Forget this.

Carolynn (00:24:51):

Why will you never forget it?

Jessica (00:24:53):

Because they were meeting in his kitchen and I walked into the kitchen and Paul's like, "Hey, Jessica, wait till you hear Justin and Emmett's new crazy idea." Justin's going to wear a camera on his head and broadcast his life in a reality TV show. And I remember, I think I said, "Well, that's a dumb idea."

Justin (00:25:15):

Yeah. I mean, everyone, that was a consensus opinion. Paul is like a savant at ideas. He's so good at ideas. He tapped into, I think something that I kind of understood, which is like people are interested in other people and they want to learn and follow other people. And that was like the precursor to social media.

Carolynn (00:25:37):

Well, let's go into this for a minute because leading up to the idea of Justin TV, was it one of those things where everyone's like, "Oh my gosh, Justin has such a crazy, interesting life." Or was it more like you guys sat down, had this idea and you're like, "I'm going to be crazy and interesting."

Justin (00:25:56):

Yeah, it was more the latter because basically I was a shy extrovert. I've kind of grown into myself now and people are surprised to hear that, but maybe you remember at Y Combinator, I was pretty shy. I wasn't out there, I was not there. I don't remember. Yeah, but I was. I was intimidated by all these other people who I though were way smarter than me. And I always wanted to be more out there, but I didn't really know how. So the idea of Justin TV was kind of my own way of forcing myself to go do interesting stuff and be out there in the world.

Carolynn (00:26:25):

How did you talk yourself into that? You were just like, "This is the next version of myself?"

Justin (00:26:30):

Yeah, I'm just like, "Fuck it. I'll try anything. I'll try anything." I don't know. I'm really good at forcing myself to do uncomfortable things just because I fast five days of no food every year in January for the last five years. I wanted to do that one year and I was like, "I've always wanted to do it, so I just yo low, let's try it. " And then I've found it to be a really interesting experience. You

Jessica (00:26:58):

Must feel amazing if you've done it five years in a row.

Justin (00:27:02):

Afterwards. Yeah. During, really not great dying. My wife says it looks like the spark has left my eyes. I'm starving to down, but afterwards I feel great. Anyways, I'm sorry, that's a total tangent, but I just like to throw myself in the deep end on things.

Jessica (00:27:22):

Yeah. Well, this idea was the deep end. I mean, you literally had a camera on your head and Emmett and Kyle, who both been on the show, talked a lot about how technically it was very difficult. This is back before there were reliable cellular connections and things, and broadcasting the video in real time was really hard, but you were sort of responsible for making sure the content was kind of interesting.

Justin (00:27:50):

Yes, which I did not do a good job of. You were the talent. I was the talent.

Jessica (00:27:54):

I feel like I want to beg to differ. And I know you got a lot of early complaints like, "Oh, we're just watching Justin Seaper."

Justin (00:28:00):

This guy sleep.

Jessica (00:28:02):

Eat breakfast. But what I remember were many of the highlights that I sort of felt like I participated in. My favorite with Michael Seibel, the startup school at Stanford

Justin (00:28:15):

Where-

Jessica (00:28:16):

We're

Justin (00:28:16):

Calling in a bomb threat? The

Jessica (00:28:18):

Bomb threat, and we were like two speakers before the event was over. We had hundreds of people and the head of security at Stanford was like, "We got to evacuate. We got to evacuate." And Michael Seibel and I were like, "No, please, please trust us when we say this is a prank. This is all a result of Justin TV and this is a hoax." And the guy was like, "I can't be taking these hoax." I'm like, "Please." And then we were on the last speaker and Carolyn, you'll appreciate this. It was our wonderful patent attorney in Boston. And I was like, "Joel, man, you got to keep this quick because they don't really want to hear about patent, so just keep it succinct." He's like, "No problem. This is going to be the shortest speech in all of startup school." It was like the longest talk in all the starter school.

(00:29:06):

I literally was crawling up onto the stage because I had the security guy breathing down my neck and I was like, "Joel, be done." It was so stressful, Justin. But the one thing that I really want you to tell is when someone swatted you and the police came to your apartment and like, didn't they kick down the door with the gun? Yeah. Will you tell that

Justin (00:29:27):

Story? Yeah, yeah. So we all moved when we moved to San Francisco for starting Justin TV. So after Paul funded Justin TV, which is the idea of like, let's do a 24 hour seven live stream, we moved to SF because we were like, our next startup should be in SF. So we moved to this building. We found this building that a bunch of YC companies eventually moved into called the YScraper. I wasn't the real name of the building.That's what we called it.

Jessica (00:29:49):

Wait, you were the first people who-

Justin (00:29:51):

Yeah, we were the first people- Moved

Jessica (00:29:53):

Into Crystal Towers is what it was called.

Justin (00:29:55):

To Crystal Tower. Yeah. And it was month to month furnished apartments in San Francisco. So are It was very convenient for startups where you might move somewhere else afterwards. And so we moved in there. The guys from Zobnie, the email thing, like Matt Brozena and Adam Smith, Dropbox guys, Reddit, Weebly. So there were a bunch of companies there and we'd have dinner once in a while together every week. People would hang out. So we launched our show six months later in 2007, March 2007. And obviously people were pranking us. They were trying to interact with the stream. All these things that happened to live streams today on Twitch or whatever were happening to us. And so one of the things that people like to do to mess with us is they would call in bomb threats or call fire department on us. They were always reporting fires at Crystal Towers.

(00:30:44):

And so they called a stabbing into our apartment, which was super not cool. Not cold. But we would keep our door unlocked because it was like friends would just come and walk in. It was kind of like Seinfeld or something. And so we had our door unlocked and we heard someone like a bang on the door four days into our stream. We just launched a stream. Someone's banging on the door and they're like, open up SF Police. And we thought it was, it sounded like Matt Brozena was another YC founder. And so we were like, "Fuck off," basically. And they kick open the door because the door was actually unlocked so legally they can enter. So they just opened it. And then the guy had his gun drawn. Kyle's sitting right here. The gun is right here. And we're like, "Yo." It's like an apartment full of nerds working on their computers.

(00:31:42):

And you can see it on the camera. I'm like, "Put my hands up like this. " I

Jessica (00:31:46):

Remember you had your hands

Justin (00:31:47):

Up. Yeah. And after that, obviously they were like, "Oh, there's no body in here. There's just a bunch of-

Carolynn (00:31:54):

Nerds.

Justin (00:31:55):

Nerds working a startup." And so they left and we were like, first of all, we told the emergency dispatch or whatever. Eventually, after they called a fire in on our poker night, there was five fire trucks outside. There's a four alarm fire or whatever. The 911 dispatcher was like, "Hey, next time we get a call to this address, we're going to call you, Michael Seibel, my co-founder, and see if it's real." We were like, "The fact that EMS works like that, you're just going to call him and if he doesn't say it's actually an

emergency, then you're not going to send anyone is crazy. But that's a good solution." And so then we were like, "Should we cancel our show? This is way too intense." People have gotten killed in swatting. I didn't even know what a swatting was until this was early internet, 2006.

(00:32:53):

So anyways, we ended up being like, "Okay, we're going to keep going. " And that was a crazy moment, but kind of died down after that.

Carolynn (00:33:05):

How long did you do Justin TV where you're actually, you were the entertainment?

Justin (00:33:08):

Well, we were streaming for six months, but basically what happened was the first four weeks was crazy. It was just viral and building on itself. And we were on MTV and the Today Show and trying to make content, but the retention was really bad because people would come and be like, "This is interesting, but this guy's actually not that interesting." And also the format of watching someone just walk around for all the time is not actually that interesting. So we kind of hit this viral moment, but it wasn't retentative. And so we ended up being like, "We need to pivot to something." Lots of people had asked, "Hey, can I create my own stream?" And so we ended up building a platform for anyone to stream, kind of like YouTube for live video, but it took us six months to actually retool to build that.

(00:33:49):

So we ended up, honestly, it probably should have been faster, but we had to build all this infrastructure. So we ended up streaming while we were building this new platform. And then in October 2007, we pivoted to be the platform.

Jessica (00:34:03):

Yeah. Okay. And there were early influencers before influencer was a word, weren't there Justine?

Justin (00:34:11):

Yeah. Yeah, exactly. The core insight I think of Justin TV was people want to follow other people and they're curious about other people's lives. And if you give them a window, they're interested. And I think it's most analogous to the stories feature of Instagram or Snapchat where people are putting up brief video clips or photos of what they're doing. And turns out in someone's 24-hour day, only one minute is potentially interesting. So we were streaming and creating content for 24 hours per 24 hours, and it should have been one minute per 24 hours. But I do think there was a core insight in there that people wanted to follow other people. And if we were smarter, we would've created a different app or something, but that's ... It worked out.

Jessica (00:34:58):

I was going to say, it turns out you were smarter because you ultimately pivoted to Twitch. Do you remember that?

Justin (00:35:03):

Yeah. So what happened was, I'll give you the bridge version, but basically we had this site that anyone could stream anything and people would stream all sorts of different stuff. And after a couple years, there was one category that we're really into, which was gaming. It really was in a big internal debate,

but Emmett was the one who's loved gaming the most. And he was like, "This is the only content that I care about and think is good on our site." So we ended up kind of nurturing that part of it and growing it. And it kind of eventually became Twitch.

Jessica (00:35:36):

Which is huge. And then you got sold for a billion dollars to Amazon, which for YC, I was like, "This is amazing." It was the biggest exit that had happened, I

Justin (00:35:47):

Think. I think at the time, yeah.

Jessica (00:35:49):

At the time.

Justin (00:35:50):

Yeah, at the time. Yeah. Remind us what

Jessica (00:35:51):

Year that

Carolynn (00:35:52):

Was.

Justin (00:35:52):

2014.

Carolynn (00:35:54):

Had you left Twitch before the acquisition or were you still involved at the time?

Justin (00:35:57):

I left before the acquisition. I was just on the board. We'd started this other company that YC funded that was called Exec and it was kind of like TaskRabbit. I don't know if you remember that.

Jessica (00:36:07):

I remember because I loved Exec. I was a busy working mom with toddlers.

Carolynn (00:36:13):

Well, you should tell the origin story, because if I'm remembering correctly, it's very entertaining.

Justin (00:36:18):

Yeah. The origin story. So this idea ... I mean, I was always thinking of ideas and Emmett was really the one who was building Twitch and I contributed some, but at the end of the day, I was like, "Okay, hits his product genius, so I'm going to do something else." So I was thinking about this new startup. I had this idea ... Well, I was going to Burning Man with the guys from Dropbox. Drew brought me to Burning Man

for the first time with a bunch of other YC founders in 2011. And then I think the next year is when I thought of it because in 2012, we were going to Burning Man and one of the guys had left his ticket at his house and we were already in Reno or something. And so he was trying to figure out how to get his ticket.

(00:37:02):

I'm like, "Hey, you should ... There's another friend of ours leaving, but you need to get a ticket from what point your lobby of your house to this other friend before that person leaves." I was like, "Call an Uber, send them to ... Uber had existed then. So send them to your address, call the guy, tell them, pick up this thing and bring it to here." And then he did that and it worked. And so after that, I was like, there should be an app where you can just hire someone in the real world to do something immediately, whatever it is. TaskRabbit, they had a long lead time. Oftentimes it was hours or days before you hired someone. I was just like, there should just be a pool of people on call to do whatever people want to do, which- Yeah. Why

Carolynn (00:37:45):

Does my memory of that story involve a pizza where there was no pizza

Justin (00:37:49):

There

Carolynn (00:37:49):

Message?

Justin (00:37:50):

There was another time when Twitch was down, this was like in the early days of Twitch, we had one engineer doing every system. So Kyle did all the video system and there was no one else who knew how it worked. Emmett did the website. No one else knew how it worked. There was another guy to do chat. No one else. No redundancies. There was no redundancy, no documentation, nothing. So if that guy got hit by a bus, we were screwed. So we were like, "Hey, Kyle went on vacation. He's like, " I'm going to go to Tahoe and I'll see you guys on Monday or whatever. "This is a time when we were working every day. So we were like, " You're going on vacation, dude. What the fuck? "So he was like, " Okay, I'm going to go on vacation. "And he was like, " You have my cell phone, so call me if you need something.

(00:38:40):

"Of course, on Saturday, our busiest time was a weekend because that's when more people were out of school at work or whatever, so we're watching. So the site goes down and we're calling Kyle and calling 10 times, no answer. So we knew where he was staying. So we called a pizza place and we were like, " Hey, can you go to this address? We'll pay you for a pizza. We'll go to this address and tell the person the website is down.

(00:39:11):

"And the guy was on the phone, he was like, " What kind of pizza do you want? "We were like-

Carolynn (00:39:16):

Any kind.

Justin (00:39:17):

"We don't want a pizza. We'll pay you for any kind of pizza. We don't want a pizza. Don't wait until the pizza's made. Just go now. Send a delivery driver right now to read this message to whoever answers the door." So they did that. It was like after explaining it for another five minutes too, we're like, "Okay, we got it. " And then Kyle, there's a ring on the doorbell. He wakes up, he's sleeping and his phone's in the other room, he was taking a nap and the guy's like, "The website is down." And then he calls us five minutes later. He just logged in, pressed one button, restart, went back up, of course. And then he calls us, he's like, "Why didn't you send the

Carolynn (00:39:55):

Pizza?" Damn it, I had a nap and now I want a snack.

Justin (00:40:00):

So anyways, that was another instance where it was like, "Whoa, we want to hire someone immediately to do something." So that's what kind of came up with the idea for exec and that didn't work. We ended up pivoting to house cleaning of all things, but it turns out people wanted certain categories of things. We should have picked delivering food or groceries because that was an obvious one that turned into Instacart and DoorDash. But instead we picked house cleaning, which was dumb for a lot of reasons. Yeah. Anyway, so that was another attempt to build something.

Jessica (00:40:39):

And you started that with Daniel, your brother, right?

Justin (00:40:42):

Started with my brother and our other friend, Amir, childhood friend. And then we worked on that for about two years. Clearly the house cleaning side. The problem with house cleaning is I think what we learned, and I thought a lot of other Silicon Valley people learned this over the years is like services doesn't necessarily scale as well, especially when they're powered by humans as technology, despite the fact that you wanted to. And so there's just a huge amount of errors and edge cases when it came to having human cleaners in people's houses to make the margin. The margins didn't really work very well. And then the user acquisition costs were too high to make the business work really well. And so at the end of two years we were like, okay, let's just ... We sold it actually. We ended up making money a little bit.

(00:41:26):

It was kind of like a Kiko situation, but we had raised $3 million or $3.5 million, but we ended up selling it to a competitor that ended up selling themselves to Angie's list years later and everybody got some cash out of it.

Jessica (00:41:39):

Oh, nice. But I mean, Justin, I'm looking, I sort of scribbled down a list of all ... You started a lot of companies because

Justin (00:41:48):

Then- I've probably started like 15 companies with going through all of them would take forever.

Jessica (00:41:54):

Which one, is there one that we should ask you about? Is there one that there's some interesting stories or lessons about?

Justin (00:42:01):

Oh, I've learned so many lessons. I think I guess that services not scaling one is one. So definitely, I think one thing that happened in the arc of Silicon Valley was people made a bunch of money with mobile and building things, different mobile things. That was kind of like in the era. There was first a bunch of web 2.0 things. Maybe you could consider Twitch that. And then there were a bunch of mobile things like Uber and Instagram. And then people started being like, Uber, let's do the Uberization of everything. And then a lot of things are more services than they are technologies to scale. And I think I made my mistake probably multiple times once with Exec. And then with Atrium, our legal startup where we're trying to scale kind of like systematize and productize the legal services, as Carolyn probably could have told me and saved me multiple years of my life, like people- Did you tell him,

Carolynn (00:42:51):

Carolyn?

Justin (00:42:52):

Probably.

Carolynn (00:42:53):

Probably.

Justin (00:42:54):

Probably. People want their lawyer to be like a consigliere that knows everything about them and is super deep with them and they are more cost agnostic, especially the people who are actually the customers you want, the clients you want. Yeah. And so trying to scale that more as a technology play, but that was not the answer at the time. Maybe it would've worked with LLMs now.

Carolynn (00:43:15):

This is a little bit of an aside from all your entrepreneurial ventures, but we were talking about this before the show started. You had this era, and I remember this distinctly because my kids were so into watching you. And we couldn't remember what platform this was. Oh, Snapchat. How do we forget? Yes, you were big on Snapchat.

Justin (00:43:37):

Yeah. That was so fun. Yeah. So I was at YC at the time. So after Exec and we sold Twitch, right when Twitch was selling, I joined YC and I was a partner for a couple years, which was really fun.

Carolynn (00:43:52):

By the way, it was fun. I love doing interviews with you

Justin (00:43:55):

And

Carolynn (00:43:56):
Fun.

Justin (00:43:57):
YC.

Carolynn (00:43:58):
Was it like 2014

Jessica (00:43:59):
To

Justin (00:43:59):
2017? 2014 to end of 2016. So like right before 2017 batch started. Two years.

Jessica (00:44:05):
I think it was five batches. Justin in the house. I know it was great.

Carolynn (00:44:08):
It was great. Very good. Justin brings great energy.

Justin (00:44:11):
And a great

Jessica (00:44:12):
Voice and a great voice. Yeah,

Justin (00:44:14):
Thank you. There were so many people who I loved doing it with. I loved it when Michael and I got to because it was like being co-founders, but without the drama and stress of like actually our company failing actively. And then Gary and I always worked really well together and it was so much fun.

Carolynn (00:44:32):
Well, go back to Snapchat though.

Justin (00:44:34):
I saw Snapchat had blown up with stories because DJ Khaled, who's this rapper, music producer, had like gotten lost on his jet ski and he had been recording Snapchats of it. Him and Miami being like, "Oh my God, I don't know if I'm going to make it. Where am I? " And it's like the sun is setting. He's driving around a jet ski and it was kind of a viral internet moment where people are like, "This is hilarious." And I was like, "What is the stories feature?" And it turns out you're just like posting. It's like Instagram stories, you're just posting these video snippets or whatever. And so I was trying to figure it out. And so I just

started posting my own stories and I was like, "What's up? It's Justin. I'm here to tell you some startup knowledge or whatever." And so I was telling people about life advice or how to start companies or stuff like we would tell me about.

Carolynn (00:45:21):

I remember when my kids showed me you were all on your exercise bike.

Justin (00:45:27):

I started being like, "Fitness is the first step to greatness." And I'd be like, "You got to work out to feel good." And so I'd be on my exercise bike working out, it was kind of fun. It was a creative side. And so I'd make these stories every day and it grew ... I was kind of like big in Silicon Valley. It was not big for real celebrity Snapchat, but I was like locally in Silicon Valley people were following it. I think no one had really created any tech influence, business content or whatever. And so people liked that. They liked the startup content. Had a lot of fun doing it, but the Snapchat as a platform kind of got killed by Instagram for the stories component. And so I didn't want to rebuild it on Instagram and then I stopped. And but years later I started doing YouTube as a way to create content around tech and things I learned about living life.

Jessica (00:46:16):

I watched one of those today.

Justin (00:46:18):

Yeah.

Jessica (00:46:18):

I watched you talk

Justin (00:46:19):

About

Jessica (00:46:19):

Your biggest moments in your life.

Justin (00:46:23):

Yeah. I basically made a YouTube video about everything I have an opinion on. And then I ran out of ... I was like, okay, I already made one on meditation. I already made one on fasting. I made one on how to start a startup or how to pitch your startup or whatever. And then I ran out of topics and now I haven't really made them very often in the last couple of years.

Jessica (00:46:42):

Will you tell us about ayahuasca?

Justin (00:46:46):

Oh yeah.

Jessica (00:46:47):

Yeah. It was on one of your important life moments, right?

Justin (00:46:51):

Yeah. Yeah. So I learned a lot about myself through all these startups and I've considered myself really blessed to have had this journey with being able to do all these amazing things and really learn about my ... Put myself in these uncomfortable moments. Start the ultimate uncomfortable moment to stretch yourself and learn. And I remember after starting Twitch, I was like, it didn't feel like enough. I'd always thought, oh, if we just like ... I think a lot of starter founders are like, "If I just get to this milestone, then I'll finally be good." And that's like first it's like, if I just get my product launch, I'll be able to take a breath. And it's like, if I get a seed, if I get into Y Combinator, if I get a Series A, if I get a Series B, if I get this customer deal, if I sell my company ... And I had went through that whole journey for like seven, eight years and then we sold the company and I was still like, I was happy for like a month.

(00:47:47):

And then I was like, "Well, now what? Now what am I supposed to do? " So ended up going to Y Combinator, but that didn't feel like I like to be more hands-on. Ultimately, I need to do things myself. And then I started another company, Atrium. And this company, it was like a legal services company. I only started because I thought it was a good business idea, but it wasn't like my passion. I just thought this could be a big company. I was looking at all my friends who were more successful, the Brian Armstrong's of the world or Brian Chesky or Drew or whatever and being like, "Oh, I should have done better. I can make more, build a bigger company or whatever." And I was always dissatisfied. And so that was my motivator. And then randomly, a friend invited me to ayahuasca and just as I've described, it's like, "I'll try anything once just to see what happens." And I'd heard about it, didn't really know much.

(00:48:43):

He described it as doing a thousand hours of therapy in one night. And a lot of people would hear that and be like, "I'm good." But I heard that and I was like, "All right, Yolo, I'd love to try it. " And so a month later, he invited me to this ceremony, ahuasca ceremony that we're doing at this house in Big Sur. And I remember showing up. First of all, I brought my wife, who it was funny because she had no idea what this was. She was like, "Hey, we haven't seen each other." I've been traveling the last couple of weekends. We haven't seen each other for a while. Let's hang out this weekend. And I'm like, "Oh, well, I want to go to this Hyawasca ceremony. Why don't you just come?" And so without context, she ended up coming and we'd show up there and walk in this house and no idea what to expect.

(00:49:33):

The first thing I saw, I remember was this guy who's now a good friend, Matthew, who's kind of like a white Stanford educated kid. And I had this hipster mustache and he was wearing a Robin hood hoodie, like the stock trading app because that was friends of his. And he was one of the facilitators. And I was like, "This is some Silicon Valley shit right here. This is Silicon Valley." And so we're sitting there, we're all kind of gathered in this house and they're like ... William, the shaman comes out and he was saying, "We're going to do the ceremony in Spanish. He didnt speak any English from Peru and we're like, okay, what does that mean? That's by no context for any of this. " And so we sit around and end up one by one and you go up and looks at it, kind of eyeballs you and then pours a cup of eyeballs and hands it to you and drink this thing.

(00:50:29):

It's kind of like the worst jungle cough syrup I've ever had. I kind of choked it down, sit down, and then they turn out all the lights and we're just sitting in the dark in a circle for 45 minutes.

(00:50:43):

And I'm like, "What's going to happen?" Nothing happens. And so- That's

Carolynn (00:50:49):

Too much anticipation, 45.

Justin (00:50:50):

Yeah, I know. I know. It was intense. Is anything going to happen? We're sitting in the dark. And then at a certain point they start doing Icaros, which are these traditional chants and they're doing these chants. It's supposed to bring out the medicine and I'm just sitting there and nothing happens. And then after about 40 minutes of that, 45 minutes of that, they say, "Hey, if anybody wants to come up and get a second cup of medicine, you're welcome to overopening the second cup and you can come up." And I remember someone had said earlier, before it started, they were like, "There's going to be a ceremony and they can have multiple cups. And if you could even conceive of standing up, walking to the front and getting a cup, then you should have another one." You

Carolynn (00:51:38):

Haven't ad enough?

Justin (00:51:39):

Yeah, you haven't had enough. So I just jump up. I'm like, phew. And I'm the first one at the front of the room. And then through the Matthews translating it from Spanish, William is like, "How does it feel?" And I was like, "I don't feel anything yet." That's a rookie move. He looks at me and he pours a giant second cup. It's like, boom. And I drink it, sit down, and then five minutes later, I'm like, start coming up super hard. And I was like, oh no, that was for sure the first one, because there's no way it had gone into my system in this amount of time. And then-

Carolynn (00:52:23):

Oh no.

Justin (00:52:24):

Basically I went into this crazy second dimension or whatever where I'm like, yeah, felt like Tron. The room is completely blacked out, right? Dark. And I felt like everything was lit up. I'm flying through this alien space city where everything's lit up.

Carolynn (00:52:42):

Christine's still there, right?

Justin (00:52:44):

Yeah. She's in another dimension though. She's standing next to me five feet away, but she could have been in Mexico or on the other side of the planet. And I was like, "I am only worried about myself right now." And so then I'm having these visions of people in my life and I remember my dad appearing in front of me and I'm screaming at him. I'm like, "Why aren't you proud of me yet? I've done so much stuff like what is going on for an hour." And then there's this other moment where I remember I'm holding this bucket and ayahuasca is a purgative sometimes. So it felt like I'm holding this bucket and I'm

throwing up in this bucket and it's like my stomach, esophagus, mouth and this bucket are one organism designed to just pump liquid this way. And I'm like, oh my God, I felt like I was so sick and I was going to die in this out of the chaos.

(00:53:40):

It's a

Carolynn (00:53:40):

Crazy story.

Justin (00:53:42):

I remember Matthew came over and he touched me. I'm kind of yelling, rocking to myself like, no, being vocalizing a lot. And people are mostly sitting there quietly and I'm freaking out, having a full on meltdown. And so he comes over and he touches my arm and he's like, "Hey, Justin, we're worried about you making a lot of noise. How are you doing?" And I was like, "I don't think I can do this. I don't know if I'm going to make it. I think I'm going to die." And he's like, "Hey, you're a strong person. Take a deep breath and be calm." And I took this breath and I went, it felt like the first breath that I'd taken in a thousand years, and I went from the worst I'd ever felt in my life to immediately calm and centered. And I'll always remember that moment because it taught me that no matter what's happening in the outside world, there's like inside your natural experience is calm.

(00:54:43):

It's like it's inert. There's nothing happening. You're just observing all of these different phenomenon in your mind. And it was relevant because a year later, I ended up breaking both my arms in a bicycle accident. I flipped over the handlebars of my bicycle and I shattered my left elbow and I broke my right elbow. Oh my

Jessica (00:55:01):

God.

Justin (00:55:01):

As I was lying there in the street and then in the ambulances are taking me to the hospital, I was like perfectly fine. I'm like calm. And I was grateful. I was like, "I'm alive and I can survive anything."

Carolynn (00:55:13):

Did you remember the ayahuasca experience?

Justin (00:55:15):

Yeah. And I went back to that experience. I was like, "Just be calm." You have the ability to be calm no matter what's happening in the world. So back to ayahuasca though, I wake up at a certain point they're like, "We're going to close this ceremony. Please sit up." And I'm like, "There's no way I can sit up." I'm lying in a fetal position, sweat has soaked through all my clothes. My arm's in the wrong hole of my jacket. I've been trying to put it on, but I didn't have the capability of figuring out how to put on a jacket. So I just had it wrapped on myself because ayahuasca can make you cold and hot, have temperature regulation difficulties. And so I'm kind of like freezing cold in this fetal position and they close the ceremony, which means that they stop, everybody's getting food and stuff.

(00:56:02):

I'm just lying there like, yo, that was crazy. And Christine also had a similar crazy one. We get up hours later, everyone's gone to bed. We're like, get up, grab some bread and coconut water. We'd been fasting since the noon or whatever. And then we go to this tent, we're staying in a glamp on this property, go into this tent and we're like, why do people do this? We need to go home right now. We should get in our car and drive back to San Francisco now. But it was 5:00 AM. So we're like, "That's crazy because three hours or whatever. We should just sleep. Then tomorrow we're just going to get in and we're going to go. " And we wake up, we're feeling better, a little bit better. They had prepared this really beautiful spread of food from Big Sur Bakery and we're like, "All right, we'll stay for lunch." It would be messed up to not stay for lunch.

(00:56:59):

So we're at lunch and then people are like, "Hey, everyone's different. Every ceremony's different. You need to do a couple in a row." Because we'd been planned to do two nights. And so they do it one night and then you do it the next night. They're like, "You should stay." And so over the course of lunch, we're kind of talked into staying again. Oh my God. And I remember that feeling that next night we're like, do the same thing, sit, drink it. And this time it starts to hit more quickly. So in 30 minutes or so, I start to come up and the whole room is kind of like glowing green, like night vision goggles, like zero dark 30. And I was like, why did I do this again? Why did I make this decision? Why

Jessica (00:57:45):

Are you doing this again?

Justin (00:57:47):

Yeah, this is insane. So that one was crazy too. Next day though, I feel incredible. I felt incredible. And I was like, wow, I feel amazing.

Jessica (00:57:57):

Why?

Justin (00:57:57):

How

Jessica (00:57:57):

Did you feel amazing? Why?

Justin (00:57:59):

Physically. I felt like I'd gone through this deep catharsis. It felt like I had let go of something. And I remember that in the months after, weeks and months after, I came to realize from that vision I saw it with my dad and I'm screaming at my dad, why aren't you proud of me yet? I realized what that symbolizes. First of all, my dad was a great dad and he was ... I didn't even know I've had any of these feelings, but really he was representative of my friends and peers and my parents. When I was a kid, I didn't feel like I got the approval that I needed from the outside world. And every decision I'd ever made in my adult life to start a company, to try to be a famous founder, to make all these social media things, to try to care what people thought about me was all because I really wanted the approval of the external world.

(00:58:47):

And that was the driving force in my life subconsciously. I wouldn't have been able to articulate it before, but I realized that about myself and that was a deep source of my own unhappiness in that I thought if I sell my company for a billion dollars or I have another unicorn or whatever, then I'll finally be happy. And I went through that whole process and I realized two things. One is that I could love and accept that part of myself. Even though it's not that attractive to admit that I just really care what other people think about me, it's like I can accept that. And it helped me. It helped me become successful, helped me have all these amazing experiences, even have the experience of doing ayahuasca, number one. And then number two is I didn't have to show up that way in the world if I didn't want to anymore.

(00:59:35):

And so I could show up in a different way. And for me, the consequence has been realizing that people will like me, not for my successes or whatever, but if I just show up as a good friend, as somebody who's genuinely interested and curious and on the people around me, people love me from who I am, number one. And number two is like, I can do things for my own intrinsic reasons, you know? And it's funny because a lot of people are like, "Hey, you were starting companies and investing before Ayahuasca and now you're starting companies and investing. So did anything change?" But it's like the place that I'm doing it from, it's like now when I'm starting companies, it's not because I want to get to some outcome. I'm like, "Oh, it has to be a billion dollars. It has to be $10 billion." Now it's like I'm doing it because the remote things I liked about entrepreneurship, which is learning about new things.

(01:00:22):

I love mentoring other people. I love coming up with ideas and applying my creative mind in business. And so I just try to do things from the intrinsic reasons now and I find myself much happier. The test I always use, which is actually what I advise other people often on is if after today, if everything I did today, all the companies or advising or whatever I did amounted to no money, they were all unsuccessful and no one ever found out about them. Would I feel like I wasted today or was it still good use of time? And if the answer is yes, then I know I'm doing things right. If the answer is no, then I'm like, I shouldn't be doing those things. That's

Carolynn (01:01:04):

A very insightful metric.

Jessica (01:01:06):

Yeah. Well, we love you no matter what. But it sounds like a very positive way to approach life. Do you think a therapist could have gotten you to the same place or do you ... I'm just curious.

Justin (01:01:23):

Yeah, I think for sure. Therapy is like ... I went to a therapist for years too, especially at times when my companies were failing and I was like, how do I motivate myself? Or I felt like burned out. I'm a proponent of all of the self-discovery modalities, whether it's therapy or ayahuasca or meditation or there's so many different things. And it wasn't so much that I just did ayahuasca and then was healed or something. It was more like I learned this insight and then I had to change things in my life to show up in a way where I was really happy with how I was showing up in the world.

Jessica (01:02:01):

I love it. Maybe this is a good place to end.

Carolynn (01:02:05):

I think so. I think it's a very positive note.

Jessica (01:02:08):

Yeah.

Justin (01:02:09):

Well, thank you guys. It changed my life for sure.

Jessica (01:02:14):

I loved just sort of catching up with you because I feel like I saw you really briefly at the retreat last summer. I saw you really briefly at the 20th reunion because I was on Planet Mars

Justin (01:02:24):

That night. There was like

Jessica (01:02:24):

A

Justin (01:02:25):

Million people there.

Jessica (01:02:26):

There's like thousands of people. Yeah. So I miss seeing you.

Carolynn (01:02:32):

Me too. Like I said before, you were such a fun coworker. Interacting and doing interviews with ... I was like, Justin is so much fun. I have only fond memories of all that.

Justin (01:02:42):

That was fun. I loved being at YC, there were so many great moments of it. Yeah. It's

Carolynn (01:02:48):

Definitely good times.

Jessica (01:02:50):

Well, thank you for coming on the show and sharing all your stories. And hopefully I'll see you around San Francisco when I'm there next.

Justin (01:02:59):

Yeah. Yeah.

Jessica (01:03:00):

This is going to be a great episode.

Justin (01:03:01):
Love it.

Jessica (01:03:02):
All right. Thanks

Justin (01:03:03):
Guys.

Jessica (01:03:03):
Bye.

Justin (01:03:04):
Bye.

Jessica (01:03:05):
Bye. Justin Kahn.

Carolynn (01:03:08):
I love his voice. His

Jessica (01:03:10):
Voice is the best. And he's

Carolynn (01:03:11):
Such a great guy. I was saying this, but he was such a fun coworker. I have really fond memories of working with Justin.

Jessica (01:03:20):
Fascinating hearing about all the ayahuasca stuff. I know zero about it, just so you know. Yeah,

Carolynn (01:03:29):
Yeah, yeah. I love how he approaches talking about it. He's an open book. He'll tell you anything. It doesn't matter if it's ... I don't think he gets embarrassed

Jessica (01:03:40):
Or

Carolynn (01:03:41):
Gets weird about anything. He's just like, "This is what happened." It's so honest. I love it. And just as he mentioned, there's 15 plus startups that he has on his resume. It's amazing to just sort of embrace

entrepreneurialship like that and just keep figuring out what, try to make something people want, figure out what you like to make, what you're interested in. I think he really has a good formula.

Jessica (01:04:11):

He and Emmett were kind of like the purest data point of funding people who were young to sort of do what they were interested in because young people like that, kind of 23-year-olds or whatever, embody future demand of things without knowing it sort of subconsciously.

Carolynn (01:04:34):

Well, and also I think Justin in particular has the skill of knowing how to hit on cultural moments. So start of social media, start of influencing the fact that he embraced, he was telling the Snapchat story, he was always like someone who was, to me, felt like he was always there first. And that's a gift.

Jessica (01:04:56):

I love it. It's going to be such a great episode.

Carolynn (01:04:58):

Yeah, he's great. All

Jessica (01:05:00):

Right, C. Levy, I will talk to you the next time.

Carolynn (01:05:03):

Okay, bye.

Jessica (01:05:04):

Bye.